MADHYA PRADESH

A Problem Called Chouhan

For the Congress, the leadership issue is settled this time in Madhya Pradesh. Kamal Nath is the CM face and he shares a great rapport with former CM Digvijaya Singh, who played a crucial role in the party winning the elections in 2018. The two have been working in sync till now, and the party's electoral campaign will mostly revolve around the 'misgovernance' of the Shivraj Singh Chouhan regime. Caste calculations are also being kept in mind as the party has set up various cells based on professions to build an inclusive vote bank. The induction of Sunil Kanugolu, the election strategist behind the Karnataka win, is also expected to provide a fillip to the Congress campaign.

However, the job may not be easy. Unlike Karnataka, where there is a change of government every five years, the BJP had an uninterrupted 15 years in power in MP between 2003 and 2018. Even in 2018, when the Congress did unseat the BJP, it was by a narrow margin—the BJP won 109 seats and the Congress 114 in the 230-member House.

IN CHHATTISGARH, THE CONGRESS HAS BEEN HIGHLIGHTING HOW THE BAGHEL GOVT PAID BONUSES FOR PADDY PROCUREMENT

The saffron party also has a stalwart in the form of Chouhan, though there are murmurs within the party that his popularity is on the wane. Speculation is rife that the central leadership is not keen to continue with him. What makes the BJP's case weaker is that state unit chief V.D. Sharma has failed to show much organisational expertise, forcing the top leadership to dither any decision on the CM face. Besides, the weakening of the local leadership may backfire on the party, as was seen in Karnataka. "The success of the BJP's central leadership can be the icing on the cake, but the cake has to be prepared locally," says political analyst Sandeep Shastri while referring to the BJP's oft-repeated slogan of 'double-engine sarkar'—BJP rule both at the Centre and in the state.

Earlier indications suggest that the BJP may fall back on polarising narratives to win back the state. A day after the Karnataka results, Chouhan mentioned the recent arrests of members of the radical outfit Hizb ut-Tahrir from Bhopal and raised the issue of conversion. At the same time, it has not lost focus on social engineering. The BJP has been carrying out an outreach programme among numerous caste-based groups in its bid to build a social coalition. Community-specific welfare boards have been announced in addition to declaration of holidays to commemorate the birthdays of community leaders.

CHHATTISGARH

Selling Sops and Soft Hindutva

This tribal-dominated state has been the strongest citadel of the Congress. In 2018, the party returned to power in Chhattisgarh after a hiatus of 15 years, winning a thumping majority, securing 68 seats of the total 90 and reducing the BJP to 15. Like Rajasthan, here too, the Congress has witnessed a bitter power tussle between Chief Minister Bhupesh Baghel and his cabinet colleague T.S. Singh Deo. While Baghel, an OBC leader, has a strong grip over the organisation and has the support of most of the MLAs, Singh Deo holds sway over the tribal seats in North Chhattisgarh. Peace between the two leaders is imperative if the Congress wants to put up a united front and that is where the central leadership's challenge lies.

In terms of narrative, the Congress has been highlighting how the Baghel government paid bonuses for paddy procurement and also adopting a soft Hindutva stand, raising issues such as procurement of cow dung, promotion of organic farming and development of the Ram Van Gaman Path (the route Lord Ram, Sita and Lakshman are believed to have taken during their exile). The focus on electoral gain is evident as all the policies, schemes and finances are directed towards the central region of the state, where 65 or so of the state's 90 assembly segments are located.

For the BJP, former CM Raman Singh remains the most celebrated face. Though the party has not groomed any leader to take over Singh's legacy, it is trying to downsize the influence of the former CM. Late last year, the national leadership changed both the party president and the leader of the Opposition, considered close to Singh. Bilaspur MP Arun Sao, who hails from the politically crucial Sahu community, was made party president while Narayan Chandel, an OBC leader, was appointed the leader of the Opposition. The party has also brought in veteran Om Mathur as Chhattisgarh in-charge, which seems to have given the impression that it is serious about the state. But the recent exit of Nand Kumar Sai, the BJP's most towering tribal leader, seems to have weakened the party's pitch on the tribal turf. Sai joined the Congress.

As far as electoral issues are concerned, the BJP has been claiming that the Baghel government has failed to deliver the benefits of the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana to the residents of the state. Also, if the alleged corruption against the BJP government contributed to the party's loss in Karnataka, it should worry the Congress in Chhattisgarh as well. The Enforcement Directorate has arrested an IAS officer and a party MLA on charges of corruption. ■